EXPLOSIVE HIP ROTATION

In the split second before the ball's release, his hips rotate toward the batter ahead of his shoulders, stretching his core like a coiled rubber band

A HYPEREXTENDED ELBOW

A natural physical trait he was born with, it allows him an unusual degree of hyperextension during release—somewhere between 40 and 45 degrees—along with lateral flexion. That extra bend introduces another whip-like component to his action and accelerates the ball further

ADVANCED RELEASE

Releases the ball significantly ahead of his body—often nearly a foot in front of his head. This unfamiliar release point surprises batsmen, effectively shortens reaction time for them and makes the delivery feel quicker

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>
> **PARAS MHAMBREY**
> *Former India bowling coach*

into the upper body, where a rapid rotation results in a whip-like release of the bowling arm. That quick rotation of the upper body is also accomplished by the pivot he forms at his waist. Right before the ball leaves his hand, his hips rotate towards the batsman before the shoulders, like a stretched rubber band snapping back into place. Think of it like a batter or golfer using their hips and core muscles to generate maximum power into a swing.

Then comes the secret sauce: the hyperextended elbow. A gift he was born with, it allows him to flex his elbow backward up to 40-45 degrees at the time of release, with a slight lateral flexion added on top of that. This unique projectile base adds another dimension to his bowling: a whip-like effect that helps propel the ball a few clicks faster than what he has already generated from his knee, core, shoulder and now the elbow. And still it's not done.

The final act involves the wrist. The hyperextension in the elbow affords him the luxury of a release point that is often a foot ahead of his head—almost 40 centimetres closer to the batter than most bowlers—further shortening reaction time while also sending the ball from an unusual position that batters aren't accustomed to. It is the coming together of all these elements that has led to a widely accepted truth: the biggest impediment in negotiating Bumrah is that the ball reaches the bat much quicker than the batter expects.

That same ability to hurry batters also makes him the owner of—not necessarily the quickest, but—certainly the most lethal yorker in the business. For most bowlers, the yorker is a risky proposition: miss your length even slightly and the batter feasts on what is now a half-volley or even a full toss. Bumrah, however, remains untouched by such worldly troubles. It's why even his half-volleys and full tosses seldom disappear over the boundary. And even though batters almost expect the yorker during clutch moments in a match, they still struggle to counter it.

The Inscrutable Indian

Then there is the dip—another one of Bumrah's weapons. The same hyperextension that allows him to generate extra pace also enables him to impart heavy backspin on the ball through his wrists. The backward rotation upon release creates a trajectory that dips further ahead of the batter than deliveries from most other bowlers operating at a similar pace and release point. Effectively, it creates an illusion—one that powers another of his weapons: the slower ball. While most fast bowlers rely on the off-cutter variation of the slower ball, Bumrah combines the conventional off-cutter with pronounced backspin, producing a heady concoction that batters find extremely difficult to negotiate. "The batter thinks it's in my slot and he gets ready to hit, only for the ball to dip drastically on him," Paras Mhambrey, who has worked with Bumrah as a coach both with India and the Mumbai Indians, explains to INDIA TODAY. "Add to that the fact that there's hardly any change in his action whether he's bowling a quicker one or a slower one—that makes it doubly hard for a batter to read him."

And to think that the very force responsible for making him a colossal figure in the sport today—his action—was neither natural nor taught. By his own admission, a young Jasprit Bumrah kept altering his action throughout his teenage years, often mimicking whichever bowler fascinated him while watching international cricket on television. The only reason the current action eventually stuck—around the age of 17—was because it placed the least strain on his body. Simple as that.

It is one thing to possess the skills and quite another to execute them with relentless precision. To credit Bumrah's success purely to biomechanics would therefore be doing a great disservice to arguably the finest fast bowler of his generation. To borrow from Muhammad Ali: "The will must be stronger than the skill." His prodigious yorkers, as unorthodox as they are, are also the result of his persistence in attacking the stumps. A habit he developed during his early years playing tennis-ball cricket, where with no swing, seam or bouncers to trouble the batter, dismantling the timber with sheer pace was often the only viable